

Churches interested in starting a financial ministry can become a part of a volunteer network established by Crown Financial Ministries. Go to crown.org for more information.

So what can I expect from a financial coach?

Too often those who ask for help from a financial coach expect too much too soon. Consequently, they become disillusioned when the coach doesn't have a magical formula that will make them debt-free in three months. Or, they expect the coach to tap the church treasury to bail them out of their troubles. In reality, fewer than 15 percent of the coaching cases I have seen (where the church was willing and able to assist them financially) actually needed direct financial support. With most of those, the financial help was temporary and only met basic needs.

A good coach will take an objective look at the total financial picture and then make recommendations that will resolve the problems permanently.

In most cases the answer for those in financial difficulties is personal discipline—not more money. Obviously there are exceptions, such as families in which a major illness has occurred or elderly people who are living on fixed incomes that are lower than the poverty level. Those are needs that must be met by other believers and generally are not one-time needs.

If there are urgent needs, such as pending foreclosures, judgments, or evictions, we try to deal with those immediately. But I make clear to everyone I counsel that there are no guarantees. If a foreclosure or eviction is imminent, it may be that nothing can be done to forestall it. Usually an experienced coach will have contacts to assist in finding temporary housing or transportation, but beyond that, his or her function is coaching—not funding.

From a coach's perspective, I can't emphasize strongly enough how many Christians expect unrealistic results from their advisers. Unfortunately, too many coaches foster those expectations by presenting themselves as authorities on a great variety of topics,